



STAFF SELECTION COMMISSION
2026-27 RECRUITMENT SEASON

The SSC 2026-27 Season Handbook

Every open application window, the OTR system done right, the twelve rejection traps, verified exam patterns and physical standards, and a 16-week Tier-1 preparation plan.

4

application windows

6,000+

posts confirmed

25,000+

more expected

16-week

prep engine

Digital Edition

Verified against the official notices published on ssc.gov.in
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What's inside

This handbook covers the full SSC recruitment season running from September 2026 to March 2027: the four application windows that are open or about to open, the application system explained step by step, the mistakes that get forms rejected, verified exam patterns and physical standards for every exam in the season, and a complete 16-week preparation plan for the Tier-1 style computer-based papers.

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1. Read this first

Every September, the Staff Selection Commission opens its biggest recruitment windows of the year - and every September, thousands of candidates lose their shot before the exam even happens. Forms get rejected for a photograph uploaded the wrong way. Fees get paid but never linked. Deadlines slip by two days. Selection is hard enough; losing it to paperwork is the part you can completely eliminate.

That is what this handbook does. It is a single, verified reference for the SSC season that runs from September 2026 to March 2027, built for the candidate who wants the whole picture in one place instead of forty browser tabs and forwarded WhatsApp messages.

What is verified, and how

Every exam fact in this book - dates, vacancies, pay levels, patterns, physical standards, fee rules - was checked against the official notices published on ssc.gov.in: the CHSL 2026 notice dated 7 September 2026, the Junior Engineer 2026 notice dated 2 September 2026, the CPO (Sub-Inspector) 2026 notice dated 10 September 2026, and the Constable GD recruitment scheme for the pattern and physical standards, plus the Commission's published examination calendar for 2026-27. Where something is an expectation based on the calendar rather than a confirmed date (the GD 2027 notification, for example), this book says so plainly.

How to use this handbook

- If an application window is open for you, go straight to that exam's chapter (Sections 4 to 7), then read Section 9 (the application walkthrough) and Section 11 (the rejection traps) before you touch the form.
- If you have not decided which exam fits you, start with Section 3, which maps qualifications to exams and pay levels.
- Once your form is submitted, move to the 16-week preparation engine in Section 15.
- Preparing for a uniformed post? Section 14 covers physical test standards and training.
- Whatever else you read, remember the one rule that overrides this book: ssc.gov.in is the only source that finally counts. The Commission can and does revise dates.

A note on money

Nothing in government recruitment requires an agent, a consultant or a 'form filling service'. The application fee for every exam in this handbook is Rs 100 - and women, SC, ST, PwBD and Ex-Servicemen candidates are exempt even from that. Anyone charging more than Rs 100 for a form, or promising selection for a fee, is running a scam. Section 17 covers the common frauds in detail.

2. The season at a glance

Seven SSC recruitments overlap in this window. Four of them - CHSL, CPO, JE and GD Constable - have application windows open right now or opening within days. The table below is the map; the following chapters are the territory.

Exam	Window / status	Papers and next stage	Roughly how many posts
CHSL 2026 (12th pass)	Open: 7 Sep to 7 Oct 2026	Tier-I, then Tier-II; dates to be notified	About 2,536

Exam	Window / status	Papers and next stage	Roughly how many posts
CPO / SI 2026 (graduate)	Open: 10 to 30 Sep 2026	Paper-I, then PET/PST, then Paper-II	About 1,871
JE 2026 (engineers)	Open: 2 to 22 Sep 2026	Paper-I Oct-Nov 2026; Paper-II Dec 2026	1,748
GD Constable 2027 (10th pass)	Expected 30 Sep to 31 Oct 2026	CBE Jan to Mar 2027 (expected)	Last cycle: 25,487
MTS 2026 (10th pass)	Closed (July 2026)	CBE Sept to Nov 2026	Varies
CGL 2026 (graduate)	Closed (June 2026)	Tier-I done; Tier-II Dec 2026	Varies
Stenographer 2026 (12th pass)	Closed (May 2026)	CBE Aug to Sep 2026	Varies

Vacancy counts marked 'about' are the tentative figures in the notices and are revised upward or downward by the Commission as user ministries confirm their requirements - always check the live vacancy table on ssc.gov.in before assuming a number. The three confirmed windows alone carry over 6,000 posts, and if GD 2027 lands anywhere near its last cycle, the season's total crosses 30,000.

What is urgent this week

If you are reading this in the third week of September 2026, three deadlines are close: the JE window closes on 22 September at 23:00 hours, CPO closes on 30 September at 23:00 hours, and CHSL closes on 7 October at 23:00 hours. The GD Constable 2027 notification is expected on 30 September per the Commission's calendar. If any of those exams are yours, the application chapters of this book are your first priority this week - not the preparation plan.

The 23:00 rule that trips people up

SSC application windows close at 23:00 hours (11 pm), not midnight - and the fee payment link stays open one day longer than the form. For CHSL 2026 the form closes on 7 October at 23:00 but fee payment is accepted until 8 October at 23:00. For CPO, the form closes 30 September and the fee window runs to 1 October. Paying the fee is not enough on its own though: if the fee does not get linked to your form, the form shows as 'Incomplete' and is rejected. Verify your payment status inside your login before you close the tab.

3. Pick your exam: qualifications, posts and pay

SSC recruits across three education levels in this season - Class 10, Class 12 and graduates (plus a separate track for engineers). Matching your qualification to the right exam is the first decision, and it is a simple one.

Your qualification	Exams open to you this season	Entry pay level
Class 10 (Matriculation)	GD Constable 2027; MTS (next cycle)	Pay Level-3 (Rs 21,700 basic)
Class 12 (10+2)	CHSL 2026; GD Constable 2027	Pay Level-2 to Level-5 (Rs 19,900 to Rs 29,200 basic)
Any graduate	CPO / Sub-Inspector 2026; CGL (next cycle)	Pay Level-6 (Rs 35,400 basic)
Engineering degree or diploma	JE 2026 (also eligible for CGL, CPO)	Pay Level-6 (Rs 35,400 basic)

Reading the pay levels

Pay levels are the Seventh Pay Commission's way of fixing basic pay. Level-2 starts at Rs 19,900 basic, Level-3 at Rs 21,700, Level-4 at Rs 25,500, Level-5 at Rs 29,200 and Level-6 at Rs 35,400. Your gross salary is basic pay plus allowances (dearness allowance, house rent, travel), which typically makes the take-home substantially higher than basic - but it varies by city and department, so treat any exact 'in-hand' figure you see on social media with suspicion. Section 13 explains the salary structure in detail.

Choosing between two exams

Many candidates can apply for more than one exam in this season - a 12th-pass candidate can apply for both CHSL and GD Constable, and a graduate for both CPO and next year's CGL. There is no bar on holding multiple applications, since each is a separate examination with a separate fee. The real constraint is the exam calendar: CHSL Tier-I and the GD computer-based exam both land in the January-March 2027 band, and their papers are similar enough (reasoning, quantitative aptitude, general awareness, English or Hindi) that preparing for one substantially prepares you for the other. Applying to both doubles your chances for roughly the same preparation effort.

An honest word about odds

SSC exams draw some of the largest applicant pools in the world; selection ratios are severe everywhere in this season. That is not a reason to skip applying - it is a reason to apply to every exam you are eligible for, to fix the paperwork so you actually reach the exam hall, and to prepare for the specific, published pattern rather than for a vague idea of 'competitive exams'. The candidates who clear are rarely the ones with secret materials; they are the ones who did the ordinary things - forms, mocks, revision - without mistakes.

Your next seven days, by reader type

Different starting points, same week. Pick your row and execute it:

You are	Do this week
10th pass, waiting for GD 2027	Open the OTR on ssc.gov.in (five minutes), get the domicile certificate application moving, start running 2 km easy four days a week, and begin GD-pattern practice: 20 questions each of reasoning, maths, GK and Hindi/English daily
12th pass	Apply for CHSL before 7 October (window, fee, correction dates in Section 4), choose the typing medium you will actually practise, and start the 16-week engine at week 1 with a baseline mock
Graduate	Apply for CPO before 30 September if you meet the physical standards (Section 5's tables - measure honestly), and simultaneously begin CGL-oriented preparation, since the same four subjects serve both
Engineer (degree or diploma)	The JE window closes 22 September - apply first, then spend the week on your branch's last five years of JE papers; the 70/30 split between engineering and general sections starts Monday
Already in an exam (MTS, CGL, Steno)	Your computer-based paper is in the Sept-Dec stretch - drop everything else this week for one full mock under exam conditions and its analysis; adjust the following weeks from what the error log tells you

4. SSC CHSL 2026: the 12th-pass window

The Combined Higher Secondary Level examination is among the largest recruitments in the country by applicant volume, hiring clerks and data entry operators across central ministries. The 2026 notice was published on 7 September 2026 with about 2,536 tentative vacancies.

CHSL 2026 - key facts**Application window:** 7 September 2026 to 7 October 2026, 23:00 hours**Fee payment until:** 8 October 2026, 23:00 hours**Correction window:** 14 to 16 October 2026**Fee:** Rs 100; women, SC, ST, PwBD and Ex-Servicemen exempt**Qualification:** 12th pass or equivalent; appearing candidates eligible if qualified by 7 October 2026**Age:** 18 to 27 years as on 1 August 2026 (born 2 Aug 1999 to 1 Aug 2008)**Posts:** LDC / JSA, Data Entry Operator (DEO), DEO Grade 'A'**Exam dates:** Tier-I and Tier-II to be notified on ssc.gov.in**Helpline:** 18003093063 (toll free)**The posts and the pay**

Post	Pay level	Basic pay range
Lower Division Clerk / Junior Secretariat Assistant	Level-2	Rs 19,900 - 63,200
Data Entry Operator	Level-4	Rs 25,500 - 81,100
Data Entry Operator	Level-5	Rs 29,200 - 92,300
Data Entry Operator, Grade 'A'	Level-4	Rs 25,500 - 81,100

The Commission allots posts on merit-cum-preference: your rank decides which of the posts you listed you actually get. Once a post is allotted it will not be changed - so do not list a post whose physical or medical standards you cannot meet (the notice gives LDC in the Border Roads Organisation as an example with separate physical standards, open to male candidates only). Getting a preference you cannot clear means the candidature is rejected for that post, not swapped for another.

Age relaxations

Category	Relaxation beyond 27 years
SC / ST	5 years
OBC	3 years
PwBD (Unreserved / OBC / SC-ST)	10 / 13 / 15 years
Ex-Servicemen	3 years after deducting military service from actual age
Central government civilian employees (3+ years service)	Up to 40 years (45 for SC/ST)
Widows, divorced women, women judicially separated (not remarried)	Up to 35 years (40 for SC/ST)

How selection actually flows

Tier-I is a screening stage: its normalized scores decide who is shortlisted for Tier-II, and separate category-wise cut-offs can apply for different post groups (DEO in specific departments carries its own cut-off line, for example). The final merit list, however, is prepared from Tier-II alone - aggregate marks in Section-I and Section-II, subject to qualifying Section-III and the skill test. One more rule decides your fate after the merit list: post preferences are collected through an online option form on the website before the final result, and a candidate who does not submit preferences in time is not considered for any post in the First Round of Tentative Allocation. The exam is not the last place you have to show up - the option form is.

Tier-I: the first computer-based paper

Part	Subject	Questions / marks	Time
I	English Language (basic knowledge)	25 / 50	60 minutes total, with a sectional timer of 15 minutes per subject
II	General Intelligence	25 / 50	
III	Quantitative Aptitude (basic arithmetic skill)	25 / 50	
IV	General Awareness	25 / 50	

Tier-I is 100 questions for 200 marks in 60 minutes. The critical design detail is the sectional timer: each of the four subjects gets exactly 15 minutes, and unused time does not carry forward. You cannot finish English in 10 minutes and spend the savings on quantitative aptitude - the section simply closes. Every practice test you take from today should be done with a per-section clock running.

Wrong answers cost 0.50 marks each. Questions are set in English and Hindi, and for Parts II, III and IV also in any regional language you opted for in the application form; the English section itself is in English. Marks in multi-shift exams are normalized using the Commission's published procedure before cut-offs are fixed.

Tier-II: one day, two sessions

Tier-II runs in two sessions on the same day. Session-I (2 hours 15 minutes) has three sections; Session-II, after a re-registration break, is the skill or typing test. Every section of Tier-II is mandatory to qualify.

Section	Modules	Questions x marks	Timing	
Section-I	A: Mathematical Abilities; B: Reasoning and General Intelligence	60 x 3 = 180	1 hour (sectional timers)	
Section-II	A: English Language and Comprehension; B: General Awareness	60 x 3 = 180	1 hour (sectional timers)	
Section-III	Computer Knowledge Test (qualifying)	15 x 3 = 45	15 minutes	
Section-IV	Skill Test / Typing Test (qualifying)	Session-II	-	10 to 15 minutes

Negative marking in Tier-II is 1 full mark per wrong answer in Sections I to III - double the Tier-I penalty. The Computer Knowledge Test is qualifying only, but mandatory. The paper is held in one day across both sessions, so there is no choosing to attempt sections on different days: you prepare all subjects together.

The typing and skill tests

- LDC / JSA typing test: 35 words per minute in English or 30 wpm in Hindi, judged on a 10-minute passage - roughly 10,500 key depressions per hour in English or 9,000 in Hindi. Your medium (English or Hindi) is fixed by what you choose in the application form and cannot be changed later. Hindi typists must type in the Mangal font only.
- DEO skill test: 8,000 key depressions per hour in 15 minutes for most departments; 15,000 key depressions per hour for DEO posts in the specific departments listed in the notice (about 3,700 to 4,000 depressions of printed matter in 15 minutes).
- PwBD candidates certified unable to type by a competent medical authority can be exempted from the typing test under the notice's prescribed certificate process.
- Start typing practice now if you are targeting LDC/JSA - 10 minutes of daily timed drills from this week beats 3 hours of panic in March.

The indicative Tier-I syllabus

Subject	What the notice lists
English Language	Spot the error; fill in the blanks; synonyms and homonyms; antonyms; spellings and mis-spelt words; idioms and phrases; one-word substitution; improvement of sentences; active and passive voice; direct and indirect narration; shuffling of sentence parts; shuffling of sentences in a passage; cloze passage; comprehension passage
General Intelligence	Verbal and non-verbal questions: semantic and symbolic analogy, symbolic operations, number and figural series, coding-decoding, problem solving, word building, numerical operations, space orientation, visual memory, discrimination, observation, relationship concepts
Quantitative Aptitude	Arithmetic of Class 10 level: number systems, computation of whole numbers, decimals and fractions, percentages, ratio and proportion, averages, interest, profit and loss, discount, mensuration, time and distance, time and work
General Awareness	India and its neighbours: history, culture, geography, economic scene, general polity including the Indian Constitution, scientific research - plus current events of everyday observation

Use this table as a syllabus audit, not a reading list: every topic you have already studied, tick; every topic you have not, it goes into the week grid in Section 15. The full syllabus paragraphs in the official notice are the authoritative version.

5. SSC CPO 2026: the Sub-Inspector window

The Sub-Inspector in Delhi Police and Central Armed Police Forces examination is the season's headline graduate-level uniformed recruitment. The 2026 notice came out on 10 September 2026 with roughly 1,871 tentative posts - Sub-Inspector (Executive) in Delhi Police, Sub-Inspector (GD) in the BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP and SSB, and a newly added post this year: Sub-Inspector (Fire) in CISF.

CPO 2026 - key facts
Application window: 10 to 30 September 2026, 23:00 hours
Fee payment until: 1 October 2026, 23:00 hours
Correction window: 8 to 10 October 2026
Fee: Rs 100; women, SC, ST and eligible Ex-Servicemen exempt
Qualification: Bachelor's degree; male candidates for Delhi Police SI must hold a valid LMV (motorcycle and car) driving licence by the physical test date
Age: 20 to 25 years as on 1 August 2026; SI (Fire) in CISF: 18 to 30 years
Pay: Level-6: Rs 35,400 - 1,12,100
Selection stages: Paper-I, PST/PET, Paper-II, Detailed Medical Examination, Document Verification
Exam dates: To be notified; Paper-I is expected around December 2026

What changed this year

- SI (Fire) in CISF is a new post, with its own physical standards and an 18-30 age band.
- Paper-I has been rebuilt: 100 questions for 100 marks in one hour, four sections of 25 questions each with a 15-minute sectional timer per section - a shift from the old 200-question, 2-hour format.
- Paper-II, not Paper-I, now decides the final merit (along with NCC bonus marks and your post and force preferences). Paper-I exists to shortlist candidates for the physical tests.
- Exam centre rules tightened: candidates now select three centres, all within the same SSC region.

- Post and force preferences are collected through an online option form after the Paper-II result.

Paper-I and Paper-II patterns

Paper	Subject	Questions / marks	Time
Paper-I	General Intelligence and Reasoning	25 / 25	15 min sectional
	General Knowledge and General Awareness	25 / 25	15 min sectional
	Quantitative Aptitude	25 / 25	15 min sectional
	English Comprehension	25 / 25	15 min sectional
Paper-II	General Intelligence and Reasoning	20 / 40	20 min sectional
	General Knowledge and General Awareness	20 / 40	20 min sectional
	Quantitative Aptitude	20 / 40	20 min sectional
	English Comprehension	100 / 200	60 min

Wrong answers cost 0.25 marks in Paper-I and 0.50 marks in Paper-II. The pattern rewards English heavily: Paper-II's English section alone carries 200 of 320 marks, more than the other three sections combined. A candidate who is strong in English and general awareness has a structural advantage in the final merit.

Physical standards (PST)

Group	Height	Chest (unexpanded - expanded)
Male - Delhi Police SI / CAPF SI (GD), General	170 cm	80 - 85 cm
Male - eligible hill area categories	165 cm	80 - 85 cm
Male - Scheduled Tribes	162.5 cm	77 - 82 cm
Male - CISF SI (Fire), General	170 cm	81 - 86 cm
Female - all SI posts, General	157 cm	Not applicable

Weight must correspond to height and age. Relaxations apply to specified hill area, Gorkha, north-eastern and ST categories as detailed in the notice - claims for relaxed standards need the prescribed certificate from the competent authority at the test.

Physical endurance test (PET)

Event	Male	Female
100 metre race	16 seconds	18 seconds
Distance race	1.6 km in 6.5 minutes	800 metres in 4 minutes
Long jump	3.65 metres (3 chances)	2.7 metres (3 chances)
High jump	1.2 metres (3 chances)	0.9 metres (3 chances)
Shot put (16 lbs)	4.5 metres (3 chances)	-

PET is qualifying - no marks, no merit weight - but it eliminates. Ex-Servicemen are exempt from PET (they still undergo PST and the medical). Written-paper toppers lose selections here every year; Section 14 gives you an eight-week training approach. After PET/PST come Paper-II, the Detailed Medical Examination and Document Verification, and the final allotment follows Paper-II marks, NCC bonus and your preference order.

The driving licence detail

Male candidates for Sub-Inspector (Executive) in Delhi Police must possess a valid driving licence for Light Motor Vehicles (covering both motorcycle and car) on the date of the Physical Endurance and Measurement Tests. If that is your target post and you do not yet have the licence, start the process now - it is a hard requirement, not a formality.

6. SSC JE 2026: the engineers' window

The Junior Engineer examination recruits Group 'B' engineers at Pay Level-6 across organisations like CPWD, the Central Water Commission, the Border Roads Organisation, the Military Engineer Services and the Farakka Barrage Project, plus Scientific Assistant posts in the India Meteorological Department. The notice, dated 2 September 2026, lists 1,748 tentative vacancies.

JE 2026 - key facts

Application window: 2 to 22 September 2026, 23:00 hours

Fee payment until: 23 September 2026, 23:00 hours

Correction window: 28 to 30 September 2026

Qualification: Degree or three-year diploma in the relevant engineering branch, depending on the post; post-wise table in the notice

Age: Up to 30 years as on 1 August 2026 (up to 32 for some posts)

Pay: Group 'B', Level-6: Rs 35,400 - 1,12,100

Paper-I: October / November 2026 (tentative)

Paper-II: December 2026 (tentative)

Paper-I and Paper-II patterns

Paper	Sections	Questions / marks	Time
Paper-I	General Intelligence and Reasoning	50 / 50	2 hours (2 hours 40 minutes for scribe-eligible candidates)
	General Awareness	50 / 50	
	General Engineering - your chosen part (Civil and Structural, Electrical, Mechanical, or the IMD / Telecom parts)	100 / 100	
Paper-II	General Engineering only - the same chosen part	100 / 300	2 hours

Negative marking is 0.25 marks per wrong answer. The engineering part of Paper-I is worth 100 of 200 marks, and Paper-II is engineering-only - this is a specialist's exam. Two hundred of your 300 Paper-II marks come from conventional degree or diploma syllabus coverage in your branch, so the competition is decided less by general-awareness cramming and more by how well you know your own branch.

Who can apply for what

Each organization specifies whether it accepts a degree, a diploma or both - for example, the Border Roads Organisation accepts a civil engineering degree or a three-year diploma, while several IMD Scientific Assistant options accept degrees in physics, electronics or computer science streams. The post-wise qualification table in the notice is the place to check your exact combination before filling the form, because the qualification is verified at document verification and a mismatch ends the candidature.

For engineers deciding between JE and the private market

A Level-6 central government post starts at Rs 35,400 basic with the full allowance stack and permanent pensionable service, in a recruitment that draws a far smaller applicant pool than any mass exam - the JE papers test your own branch, which you already studied for four years. If your degree or diploma is in civil, electrical or mechanical engineering, applying costs Rs 100 and a Sunday. The window closes on 22 September 2026.

7. SSC GD Constable 2027: the biggest window of all

Constable (General Duty) recruitment is the single largest exam in this season by posts - the last cycle advertised 25,487 constable posts across the BSF, CISF, CRPF, ITBP, SSB, SSF and Assam Rifles. For the 2027 cycle, the Commission's published calendar places the notification on 30 September 2026, the application window from 30 September to 31 October 2026, and the computer-based examination between January and March 2027. These are calendar dates - the notification itself will confirm them, and vacancies for 2027 will be announced with it.

GD Constable 2027 - what is known now

Notification: Expected 30 September 2026 (as per SSC's exam calendar 2026-27)

Application window: Expected 30 September to 31 October 2026

Computer-based exam: Expected January to March 2027

Qualification (last cycle): Class 10 pass from a recognised board

Age (last cycle): 18 to 23 years

Pay (last cycle): Level-3: Rs 21,700 - 69,100

Vacancies: To be announced with the notification (last cycle: 25,487)

Selection stages: Computer-based exam, PET/PST, Detailed Medical Examination, Document Verification

The computer-based exam pattern

Part	Subject	Questions / marks
A	General Intelligence and Reasoning	20 / 40
B	General Knowledge and General Awareness	20 / 40
C	Elementary Mathematics	20 / 40
D	English / Hindi (your choice)	20 / 40
	Total: 80 questions, 160 marks, 60 minutes, +2 per correct, -0.25 per wrong	

The paper is available in 15 languages - English, Hindi and 13 regional languages including Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu - which is why GD

draws applicants from every part of the country. Minimum qualifying marks in the CBE are 30 percent for unreserved candidates, 25 percent for OBC and EWS, and 20 percent for SC and ST.

Physical tests, carried over from the recruitment scheme

Event	Male	Female
Race (all candidates except Ladakh region)	5 km in 24 minutes	1.6 km in 8.5 minutes
Race (Ladakh region)	1.6 km in 7 minutes	800 metres in 5 minutes
Height - General	170 cm	157 cm
Height - Scheduled Tribes	162.5 cm	150 cm
Chest - General / ST (males only)	80 - 85 cm / 76 - 81 cm	Not applicable

These standards come from the constable recruitment scheme administered under the Ministry of Home Affairs; the 2027 notification will restate them. Candidates shortlisted from the CBE go through biometric verification before PET/PST, and the medical examination allows one review opportunity if you do not clear it the first time.

Two things to prepare before the notification

- A domicile or permanent residential certificate for your state, if you are applying against state-wise vacancies - CAPF constable vacancies are allotted state-wise, and the certificate is checked at document verification.
- Running. The male PET is a 5 km race in 24 minutes. It is the single most common reason written-exam qualifiers do not make it to the merit list. Section 14 has the training plan - start it in September, not in February.

8. The rest of the calendar, and your repeat attempts

Three exams in this season have already closed their application windows but are still live events for candidates already in them - and a preview of what opens again next year for everyone else.

Exam	Where it stands	What it means for you
MTS 2026	Window closed July 2026; computer-based exam September to November 2026	If you are in it, your exam is imminent. If not, the next cycle is your 10th-pass backup alongside GD
CGL 2026	Tier-I held August to September 2026; Tier-II in December 2026	Graduates not in this cycle should target CGL 2027 - its notification typically appears in the first half of the year
Stenographer 2026	CBE held August to September 2026	Watch for the skill test (stenography) schedule if you qualified the CBE

Why one preparation serves many exams

Look back at the pattern tables in Sections 4 to 7 and a picture emerges: the core of every SSC computer-based paper is the same four subjects - reasoning, quantitative aptitude, general awareness and English (or the English/Hindi choice at the GD level). A candidate who spends October to February preparing these four subjects to Tier-I depth is simultaneously ready for CHSL Tier-I, the GD CBE, CPO Paper-I and next year's CGL Tier-I. Only the depth, the negative-marking severity and the sectional-timer layout change, and those are adjustments of weeks, not months. This is why Section 15 is written as one engine that adapts to any of the four.

If this is your second or third attempt

Repeat candidates have one asset nobody else has: a real exam score. Use it honestly. Pull your scorecard, your shift's response sheet and the final answer key, and rebuild your section-wise accuracy. Most repeat candidates discover they were not weak everywhere - they were weak in one section and slow in another, and they spent their year improving a third thing they were already good at. The error-log method in Section 15 is built to prevent exactly that in the next cycle.

9. OTR and the application form, done right

Every rejection story in SSC recruitment starts the same way: someone was in a hurry with the form. This section walks through the whole process the way the notices actually describe it, so nothing in the portal surprises you.

One-Time Registration: your SSC identity

SSC moved to a new website at ssc.gov.in, and One-Time Registration is its central account. You register once - name, date of birth, email, mobile, basic details - and that OTR then applies to every SSC examination you ever sit. Two facts from the notices matter enormously here:

- An OTR created on the old ssc.nic.in website does not work on the new one. If your last application was before the shift, you must register afresh on ssc.gov.in.
- Your date of birth in the application must match your matriculation (Class 10) certificate exactly. The Commission accepts the DOB as filled and never entertains a change request later - a mismatch here surfaces at document verification and ends the candidature.

Aadhaar-based authentication

During registration or application you may complete Aadhaar-based authentication. The notices give authenticated candidates a specific protection: their applications are not rejected on the grounds of photograph or signature not meeting specifications - the two biggest rejection causes in the system. If your Aadhaar details are in order, use it. (Candidates who bring their own scribe follow a separate mandatory OTR-and-Aadhaar process for the scribe described in the notice.)

Documents to keep ready before you start

- An active email ID and mobile number that will stay yours through the whole recruitment - admit cards, results and option forms all land here.
- Class 10 certificate (date of birth) and your qualification certificates or marksheets.
- Category certificate in the prescribed format from the competent authority, if claiming SC, ST or OBC. OBC claims must reflect the current central list; the notice counts your status as on the application closing date.
- EWS candidates: an Income and Asset certificate valid for financial year 2026-27, issued on the basis of income for financial year 2025-26 - the CHSL notice spells this out, and a certificate for the wrong year is a document-verification failure.
- Aadhaar card (or Virtual ID), and a passport-style photograph taken on a plain background with a full frontal view, no cap, no sunglasses, no spectacles if avoidable.
- Your scanned signature as a JPEG of 10 to 20 KB, about 6 cm wide and 2 cm high - not a miniature, not blurred.

- For GD: your domicile or permanent residential certificate. For CPO Delhi Police (male): the LMV driving licence.

Filling the exam application

With your OTR done, the exam form itself is a series of modules: personal details pulled from your OTR, educational qualifications, category, exam centre choices, and post preferences. The photograph is captured inside the application module itself - you do not need a pre-existing photograph file. The notice is unusually specific about this capture, and the rules are absolute:

- 1 Capture the photograph live in the module, on a plain background, full frontal view, no cap or mask, and no spectacles. Face fully inside the marked area, neither too close nor too far.
- 2 Never photograph an existing printed photograph. Every application where a photograph of a photograph is detected is rejected summarily - unless it was filed through Aadhaar-based authentication.
- 3 Your appearance at the exam hall must match the photograph in the application. The gate checks this at biometric verification.
- 4 Choose exam centres with care: CPO 2026 requires all three chosen centres to fall within the same SSC region; centre allocation is the Commission's call and can be changed by it.
- 5 Fill post preferences in the genuine order you want them (see the CHSL note in Section 4 - an unattainable high preference is a trap, not a strategy).
- 6 Pay the Rs 100 fee online (BHIM UPI, net banking, or Visa, Mastercard, Maestro and RuPay cards), then open 'Payment Status' in your login and confirm the fee shows as received. If it does not, the form stays 'Incomplete' and will be rejected.
- 7 Submit days before the deadline. The Commission explicitly warns that it is not responsible for last-day server load - a crashed submit on the final evening is nobody's problem but yours.
- 8 Print the submitted application and the fee receipt and keep them for at least three years - SSC asks candidates to retain records for future considerations.

The correction window

After each window closes, SSC opens a short correction window (CHSL: 14-16 October; CPO: 8-10 October; JE: 28-30 September). You can re-submit a corrected form - the CHSL notice permits two corrections in the window - and correction charges apply. Treat the window as a seatbelt, not a plan: several fields, including things locked to your OTR identity, cannot be fixed there, and a candidate who 'will fix it in the correction window' often finds the one field that could not be fixed was the one that mattered.

Fees, refunds and receipts

The fee is Rs 100 per exam, payable online only. Fee once paid is not refunded under any circumstances, nor adjusted against any other examination - the notices state this without exceptions. Women, SC, ST, PwBD and Ex-Servicemen candidates pay nothing at all. Correction charges, where you use the correction window, are likewise non-refundable.

The two-minute pre-submission checklist

Before your finger touches 'Submit', run this list. It takes two minutes and covers every rejection trap in Section 11:

- 1 My OTR is on ssc.gov.in - not a remembered login from the old ssc.nic.in.

- 2 Name and date of birth match my Class 10 certificate exactly.
- 3 My category claim matches a certificate I hold, in the prescribed format, valid for the right year.
- 4 The photograph was captured live in the module - plain background, full frontal view, no spectacles.
- 5 My signature file is a JPEG of 10-20 KB, roughly 6 cm by 2 cm, sharp and full-size.
- 6 My exam centre choices follow the rules for this exam (CPO: all three within one region).
- 7 My post preferences are in the order I can actually clear - physical, medical and educational standards included.
- 8 My typing-test medium (CHSL) is the one I have actually practised.
- 9 The fee is paid and 'Payment Status' in my login shows it received.
- 10 I have the printout, the fee receipt, and the correction window dates in my diary.

10. The first 48 hours after a notification drops

A notification changes your week. The window is usually 30 days, but the candidates who suffer are the ones who treat day 30 as the deadline. Here is the 48-hour sequence that removes all the risk - written for the GD 2027 notification expected on 30 September, and identical for any notification that follows.

When	Do this	Why it matters
Hour 0-2	Download the official notification PDF from ssc.gov.in and read the eligibility paragraphs for your specific post - qualification, age cut-off dates, physical standards	News summaries routinely miss post-specific conditions; the PDF is the law of this recruitment
Hour 2-6	Complete your OTR (or confirm it exists) on ssc.gov.in; check Aadhaar details; get the signature scanned to spec	OTR problems surface exactly when you are in a hurry; done early, they cost nothing
Day 1 (morning)	Fill the application end to end in one sitting: details, centres, preferences, live photo capture	Fresh eyes in one pass beat five half-finished attempts across five days
Day 1 (same day)	Pay the fee, then verify 'Payment Status' inside your login; print the application and receipt	An unlinked fee leaves the form Incomplete - the quietest rejection in the system
Day 2	Diary the correction window dates; start the prep clock (the exam is closer than it feels); GD candidates, start the running plan	The two days after applying are the highest-motivation days of the year - spend them starting, not scrolling

The rule behind the table: apply within the first five days of any window. Nothing about a form improves with waiting, and everything about it can break - server load on the final days is documented in every recruitment season, and the Commission warns about it in every notice.

11. The twelve rejection traps

Twelve ways candidates lose their candidature before the first question is asked - each taken from the rules of this season's notices, each avoidable in under a minute.

Trap 1: Using the dead website's OTR

Old ssc.nic.in registrations do not function on ssc.gov.in. If you apply with an old OTR number or assume your old login exists, you burn days. Register afresh on ssc.gov.in first, today.

Trap 2: Photographing a photograph

The live photo capture is a rule, not a suggestion. Any application where the uploaded photo is detected as a photo of a pre-existing photo is rejected summarily. Aadhaar-authenticated applications are the only exception. Take the photo fresh, in daylight, plain background, face filling the marked area.

Trap 3: The blurred or miniature signature

Signatures must be a JPEG of 10 to 20 KB at roughly 6 cm by 2 cm. Blurred or miniature signatures are rejected - again, Aadhaar-authenticated candidates are exempted. Sign big, on white paper, with black ink, and scan straight, not at an angle.

Trap 4: Fee paid, but not linked

Money leaving your account is not the same as SSC receiving it against your form. An unlinked fee leaves the form 'Incomplete', and incomplete forms are rejected with no hearing. After payment, open 'Payment Status' inside your login and see the fee marked received - before you close the tab.

Trap 5: Date of birth that does not match Class 10

The DOB you enter is treated as final and checked against your matriculation certificate. No change request is entertained later. A one-digit typo that rides along until document verification ends the candidature at the worst possible moment - after you have passed everything else.

Trap 6: Category and EWS certificate problems

Your reserved-category claim must hold on the closing date of applications, with a certificate in the prescribed format from the competent authority. EWS claims need the Income and Asset certificate valid for 2026-27, based on 2025-26 income. Uploading a casual 'income certificate' from a local office instead of the prescribed format is one of the most common document verification failures.

Trap 7: Missing the qualification cut-off date

Appearing in the final year is fine only if the notice allows it with a deadline: CHSL 2026 counts your qualification as on 7 October 2026, and each other notice fixes its own crucial date. If your result arrives even a week after your exam's cut-off, the candidature is void - apply next cycle instead.

Trap 8: Same photograph, different details

Using the same photograph with different personal details (name, parents' names, date of birth) across different recruitments is treated as an unfair means case - the penalty runs from one to five years of debarment from all SSC exams. One identity, everywhere, forever.

Trap 9: Preferences that outpace your own eligibility

Post allocation is merit-cum-preference and final. Preferencing a post whose physical, medical or educational standards you cannot meet - like BRO's LDC with its own physical standards - gets you allotted to it and then rejected out of it, with no re-allotment to the next preference. Preference lists go in the order you can actually clear, not the order of the pay table.

Trap 10: Skipping the correction window

The window is short (two to three days per exam) and it is the only official chance to fix an error. Diary the exact dates for your exam the day you submit - CHSL: 14-16 October; CPO: 8-10 October; JE: 28-30 September.

Trap 11: The typing medium you did not mean

CHSL candidates choose English or Hindi as the typing-test medium in the application form itself, and the choice is final; Hindi candidates must type in Mangal font only. If you are a fast English typist who carelessly picked Hindi - or cannot type in Mangal - the typing test is where the run ends.

Trap 12: Not keeping your records

SSC asks candidates to retain the application printout, fee receipt and question papers for at least three years because candidatures can be considered by other agencies later. One folder, cloud plus print, every document, from the day you apply.

12. Patterns, penalties and the arithmetic of attempting

Four numbers decide how you should approach any SSC paper: questions, marks, time per section, and the penalty per wrong answer. This section puts them side by side, then works out what the penalty actually means for how many questions you should attempt.

Paper	Questions / marks	Duration	Penalty per wrong answer
CHSL Tier-I	100 / 200	60 min (4 x 15 min sectional)	-0.50
CHSL Tier-II (Sections I-III)	135 / 405	2 hr 15 min, one day, 2 sessions	-1.00
CPO Paper-I	100 / 100	60 min (4 x 15 min sectional)	-0.25
CPO Paper-II	160 / 320	2 hours (sectional)	-0.50
JE Paper-I	200 / 200	2 hours	-0.25
JE Paper-II	100 / 300	2 hours	-0.25
GD CBE	80 / 160	60 minutes	-0.25 (each correct: +2)

What sectional timers change

In CHSL Tier-I and CPO Paper-I, every section is a separate 15-minute island. The old SSC craft of finishing your strong section fast and raiding extra time for your weak one is dead - the section closes on schedule whether you are done or not. Preparation has to change accordingly: every subject needs to reach a floor of speed on its own, because no subject can subsidise another. This is also good news - it makes the paper fairer and rewards balanced candidates, and it is exactly how the practice plan in Section 15 trains you.

Should you guess? The arithmetic, honestly

The expected value of a guess is the probability of being right times the marks, minus the probability of being wrong times the penalty. With four options, a completely blind guess is right a quarter of the time. Run the numbers for this season's papers:

Paper	Marks for correct / penalty for wrong	Blind guess is worth	Break-even accuracy
CHSL Tier-I	+2 / -0.50	+0.125 per guess	20%
CHSL Tier-II	+3 / -1.00	0 per guess	25%
CPO Paper-I	+1 / -0.25	+0.0625 per guess	20%
CPO Paper-II	+2 / -0.50	+0.125 per guess	20%
GD CBE	+2 / -0.25	+0.3125 per guess	about 11%

Read that right: in every paper except CHSL Tier-II, even a coin-toss guess has positive expected value, and a guess after eliminating even one option is clearly profitable. In CHSL Tier-II the blind guess is exactly neutral - guess there only when you can eliminate at least one option. The practical rules that follow: never leave a question blank in GD, CHSL Tier-I or either CPO paper; carry elimination habits into every mock; and never let fear of the penalty make your attempt count 70 out of 100.

Accuracy still wins, of course - a worked example on CHSL Tier-I's 200-mark scale: 90 attempts at 85 percent accuracy score about 146; 70 attempts at 95 percent score about 131. Volume with decent accuracy beats caution with excellent accuracy. The plan in Section 15 pushes attempt volume up gradually, mock by mock, while holding accuracy above 85 percent.

Normalization, in plain words

When an exam runs across multiple shifts, the shifts differ slightly in difficulty. SSC adjusts for this using a normalization procedure it published on 2 June 2025, and the normalized score - not your raw score - is what sets cut-offs and merit. You cannot game it and you need not fear it, but two practical consequences follow: do not judge yourself by raw mock-to-shift comparisons floating around on the internet after your exam, and never walk out of a shift assuming a 'tough paper' has finished your chances.

Answer keys and the Rs 50 challenge

Tentative answer keys are published on ssc.gov.in after each computer-based exam. You can challenge a question online, within the given window, at Rs 50 per question - non-refundable, and the only accepted mode (letters and emails are not entertained). Challenges are reviewed before the final key is fixed. There is no re-evaluation or re-checking of scores at any stage, for any tier - the Commission's rules close that door completely.

13. Pay levels and what you actually earn

'Basic pay' on a recruitment poster is the smallest number in your salary. Here is how a central government salary is actually built, and where each exam in this season lands.

Pay level	Basic pay (start)	Posts in this season
Level-2	Rs 19,900	LDC / JSA (CHSL)
Level-3	Rs 21,700	GD Constable
Level-4	Rs 25,500	DEO, DEO Grade 'A' (CHSL)
Level-5	Rs 29,200	DEO (higher posts, CHSL)
Level-6	Rs 35,400	Sub-Inspector (CPO); Junior Engineer

How the gross is built

On top of basic pay come three main allowances: dearness allowance (DA), which is a percentage of basic revised periodically to track inflation; house rent allowance (HRA), which depends on whether you are posted in a Class X, Y or Z city; and travel allowance. Gross pay is the sum, and from it come deductions - National Pension System contribution, CGHS or equivalent health cover, and income tax at source. Two candidates with the same pay level, posted in different cities, take home visibly different amounts.

Why the exact 'in-hand salary' figures you see online are guesses

DA and HRA rates change with revision cycles, and allowances differ by department and city class. Any specific rupee figure quoted for take-home pay - Rs 60,000, Rs 70,000 - without a city, a year and a department attached is a guess. Basic pay and the pay level are the only salary facts that are fixed; everything else is structure. The basic-pay table above is what you should compare offers by.

Competition follows pay (and prestige)

Level-6 posts - Sub-Inspector and Junior Engineer - sit at the top of this season's table, which is why their per-seat competition is the fiercest: about 1,871 CPO posts against a national applicant pool that runs into lakhs, with a graduate-level paper and physical tests filtering it. GD Constable compensates for its Level-3 pay with sheer volume of posts - 25,487 in the last cycle. When you weigh your odds, weigh posts, not just pay: a Level-2 post you convert beats a Level-6 post you miss by 0.5 marks.

14. Getting physical-test ready

For CPO and GD candidates, the recruitment is two exams in one: a written paper you study for and a physical test you train for. The written paper decides whether you reach the physical; the physical decides whether the written score was worth anything. Eight weeks of honest running closes the gap for almost everyone.

Know your exact target

For CPO, the PET is sprint-and-power: 100 metres in 16 seconds (men), a 1.6 km run in 6.5 minutes, and the jumps and shot put listed in Section 5. For GD, it is endurance: 5 km in 24 minutes for men, 1.6 km in 8.5 minutes for women. These are different athletic profiles - CPO rewards short, explosive work; GD rewards steady distance - so train for your exam, not for 'fitness' in general.

The eight-week running approach

- 1 Weeks 1-2 (base): four easy runs a week at conversational pace - 2 km building to 3 km for CPO targets, 3 km building to 4 km for GD. Time nothing. Finish everything.
- 2 Weeks 3-4 (build): five runs a week; one run becomes a 'target-pace fraction' session - CPO candidates run 800 m repeats at the pace needed for 1.6 km in 6.5 min, with 3-minute recoveries; GD candidates extend the long run to 5-6 km easy.
- 3 Weeks 5-6 (specific): the sessions now look like the test. CPO: 1.6 km time trials twice a week, plus one 100 m acceleration day. GD: 5 km at target pace once a week, one easy long run, one interval day.
- 4 Weeks 7-8 (peak and taper): full-distance rehearsals at target pace early in week 7, then cut volume by a third in week 8 while keeping one sharp session. Rest the last two days before the test.

Two rules protect the plan: never increase weekly distance by more than about 10 percent, and never test maximum speed on consecutive days. Shin pain that persists past a warm-up is a rest signal, not a weakness signal - a two-day rest in week 4 costs nothing; a stress fracture in week 5 costs the recruitment.

The field events, and the one nobody trains

CPO's long jump (3.65 m men, 2.7 m women), high jump and shot put get three chances each - but three chances pass quickly for an untrained jumper, because technique, not strength, decides standing jumps. Ten minutes of practice arm swings and jump-landing drills twice a week is, in practice, the difference. Shot put is the event nobody trains and everybody fails narrowly: find a coach or a strong video tutorial for the glide technique and practise with any 7 kg implement. Male candidates need 4.5 metres from a 16-pound shot; that is a technique problem, not a gym problem.

Weight, medicals and measurement day

PST measures height and chest, and weight must be proportionate to height and age - a crash diet in the fortnight before the test to 'make weight' usually costs performance in the race that follows it. At the medical examination, candidates who fall short on the first pass get one review opportunity under the GD scheme; treat it as your safety net, not your plan. On measurement day, claims for relaxed standards (hill areas, ST, Gorkha and north-eastern categories) must be backed by the prescribed certificate from the competent authority - carry the original.

PET/PST day checklist

- The call letter, an original photo ID, and the original certificates backing any relaxed-standard claim (hill area, ST, Gorkha, north-eastern).
- Clothing and shoes you have actually run in before - new shoes on race day is the classic self-inflicted injury.
- Water, a banana or dates, and nothing heavy for two hours before your race slot.
- Arrive early enough to register, warm up and walk the course layout; the biometric queue at GD PET/PST centres is long and slow, and it precedes every test.
- No jewellery, no watches, no phones on the track; measurement of height and chest happens first, and weight is checked against proportionality to height.
- For CPO, know your event order and the three-chances rule for jumps and shot put: use the first attempt at 80 percent effort to calibrate, and the second and third to clear.

15. The 16-week Tier-1 preparation engine

Work backwards from the calendar. GD's computer-based exam is expected January-March 2027, CHSL Tier-I will follow in its notified window, CPO Paper-I is expected around December 2026, and JE Paper-I lands October-November 2026. Sixteen weeks from late September 2026 covers every one of them. This section is one engine that adapts to whichever paper you are sitting, because - as Section 8 showed - they are the same four subjects.

The weekly structure

Six days a week. Full-time aspirants run about 6 hours a day; working candidates should protect a non-negotiable 3 (two before work, one after, or the reverse). The split that works for the SSC pattern: two days quantitative aptitude, two days reasoning and English in rotation, one day general awareness, and one full mock-and-analysis day. Sunday is half rest, half revision of the week's error log - the error log is the actual engine of this plan, more on it below.

The 16-week grid

Weeks	Quantitative aptitude	Reasoning + English	General awareness	Mocks
1-2	Number systems, simplification, percentages	Analogies, series, coding-decoding; start daily PYQ vocabulary	Polity (Constitution) begins	1 baseline mock
3-4	Ratio and proportion, averages	Syllogisms, blood relations, direction sense; grammar rules	Modern Indian history	1 mock
5-6	Profit and loss, simple and compound interest	Ranking, missing numbers, embedded figures; reading comprehension daily	Geography of India	1 mock
7-8	Time and work	Non-verbal set (mirror, folding); cloze tests	Economy basics	1 mock + full previous-year paper 1
9-10	Speed, time and distance	Mixed sectional drills on 15-minute clocks	General science: biology, chemistry	2 mocks
11-12	Mensuration (2-D, then 3-D)	Mixed drills; one-word substitution and idioms	Static revision + current affairs of the last 6 months	2 mocks
13-14	Data interpretation + your weakest three topics from the error log	Error-log revision only	First full revision of your notes	2 mocks + previous-year paper 2
15	Error-log revision only	Timed sets daily	Current affairs final pass	Alternate-day mocks
16	Taper: light revision, formulas sheet	Exam-day rehearsals	Light revision only	2 light mocks, early in the week

Quantitative aptitude: the topic ladder

SSC arithmetic is a ladder, not a syllabus - each rung bears the next. Percentages before profit and loss; ratio before averages; averages before mixtures; everything before data interpretation, which is simply arithmetic under time pressure. A candidate who rushes past shaky percentages to 'finish the syllabus fast' rebuilds the same weakness in every later topic. The grid above sequences the ladder in the order it should be climbed.

Reasoning: the fastest section, treated that way

Reasoning is where SSC papers give away marks at speed: analogies, series, coding-decoding, syllogisms, blood relations, direction sense, ranking, missing numbers, and the non-verbal set (mirror images, paper folding, embedded figures). Practice reasoning with a stopwatch always running - the section is not difficult, it is quick, and your edge is seconds per question, not wisdom. Fifteen minutes for 25 questions is the CHSL and CPO Tier-1 rhythm; drill to it.

English: build from the exam's own vocabulary

SSC English recycles its own vocabulary relentlessly - synonyms, antonyms, idioms, one-word substitutions and spellings drawn from a pool that previous year papers illuminate better than any wordlist. Work one previous paper's vocabulary section per day into a notebook, with the word, its meaning and the sentence from the paper. Grammar (spot the error, sentence improvement, active-passive, direct-indirect) rewards a single good grammar text read once slowly, then exercises forever. Reading comprehension is a daily 20-minute habit.

General awareness: the subject you cannot cram

GA splits into static (history, geography, polity, economy, general science) and the last 8-12 months of current affairs. Static is finite - a standard one-volume compilation worked through at one chapter every two days finishes it inside 12 weeks. Current affairs is a daily 20-minute habit: any one daily or monthly compilation, but daily. For CPO candidates this subject is doubly critical - general knowledge and awareness carries 40 marks in Paper-II, and English plus GA together are 150 of the 320 that decide the final merit.

The error log, and the mock cadence

Every question you get wrong goes into one notebook with three columns: why (concept gap, silly slip, or time pressure), the fix (the rule, the formula, the fact), and the date you last revised it. Mocks exist to fill this notebook: one full mock per week in weeks 1-8, two per week in weeks 9-13, alternate days in weeks 14-16 - always in exam conditions, always with per-section timers for CHSL and CPO. The hour after each mock, spent on the log, is worth more than the mock itself: an unanalysed mock only measures you; an analysed one changes you.

Previous-year questions, used properly

SSC's four papers share a question DNA - GD's elementary mathematics is CHSL's quantitative aptitude at gentler depth, CPO's reasoning is CHSL's reasoning with a physical test waiting after it. Work the last four to five years of papers of your own exam first, then the same years of the adjacent exams as bonus sets. Do them twice: once timed, once untimed with full solutions - the untimed pass is where the learning happens. SSC publishes previous papers and answer keys on its website; every coaching compilation is downstream of them.

Typing, for CHSL candidates

Ten minutes daily on any free typing tutor, from now until the exam. The targets from the notice: 35 wpm in English or 30 wpm in Hindi, judged on a 10-minute passage - with Hindi candidates typing in Mangal font only. Accuracy beats raw speed in the SSC marking, because errors are counted to two decimal places. Typing is the only part of this exam where daily minutes in September convert directly into a passed skill test in March.

What one study week actually looks like

Plans fail when they stay abstract. Here is the same week translated for two real situations - a full-time aspirant and a candidate preparing alongside a job. Both hit the same subjects; only the clock differs.

Day	Full-time aspirant (6 hrs)	Alongside a job (3 hrs)
Mon	Quant: topic of the week (2 hr) + 50 practice questions (1 hr); GA: polity chapter (1 hr); vocab + RC (1 hr); typing 10 min (CHSL)	Before work: quant topic (1 hr). Commute: GA audio/flashcards. Night: 30 practice questions + 20 vocab (1 hr)
Tue	Reasoning: topic drills on a 15-min clock (2 hr); English grammar (1.5 hr); GA current affairs (1 hr)	Before work: reasoning set on the clock (1 hr). Night: English grammar (1 hr) + vocab (15 min)
Wed	Quant: mixed practice from error log (1.5 hr); GA: static chapter (1 hr); English RC + cloze (1 hr); typing 10 min	Before work: quant mixed set (1 hr). Commute: current affairs. Night: RC + cloze (1 hr)
Thu	Reasoning + English combined sectional test (2 hr) + full analysis (1 hr); GA (1 hr)	Night: one 60-min sectional test (reasoning + English mix) + 30-min analysis; commute GA
Fri	Quant: topic of the week, advanced set (2 hr); vocab and idioms (1 hr); weak-subject hour from error log (1 hr)	Before work: quant set (1 hr). Night: error-log revision + vocab (1 hr)
Sat	Full mock in exam conditions (2 hr) + 2-hour analysis filling the error log; typing 10 min	Morning: full mock (2 hr) + 1-hour analysis - protect this block; it is the core of the week

Day	Full-time aspirant (6 hrs)	Alongside a job (3 hrs)
Sun	Half day: revise the week's error log (1.5 hr); rest	Rest, plus 30 min of light error-log revision

If you are preparing alongside a job

Three protected hours daily beat six aspirational ones. The arrangement that survives: one hour before work on your weakest subject (the mind is freshest), one hour at lunch or commute on general awareness and vocabulary (these travel well - audio notes, flashcards), and one hour at night on practice, not reading. Weekends carry the mock and its analysis. Working candidates who clear SSC exams do not find more time; they simply never negotiate with the three hours.

JE candidates: your engine runs differently

Everything above applies to your reasoning and general awareness 50 questions, but your paper is decided by the 100 engineering questions in Paper-I and all 300 marks of Paper-II. Spend 70 percent of your week on your branch's conventional syllabus - worked through your own degree or diploma textbooks, which are better than any coaching note - and 30 percent on the general sections. Solve the last several years of JE papers in your branch; SSC's engineering papers repeat concepts with remarkable loyalty.

The last 24 hours, and exam morning

The final day is for tapering, not learning. No new topics, no new books, one light pass through the error log and the formula sheet, and an early night - sleep is the highest-yield study method in the last 24 hours. Prepare the bag the night before: printed Admission Certificate, original photo ID, a water bottle, and nothing electronic. On the morning, eat something familiar and light, reach the centre a full hour before the reporting time, and expect queues at biometric verification. In the hall, the first two minutes belong to reading instructions and the palette, not to the first question. Your only job in that room is to run the exact drill you rehearsed every Saturday for sixteen weeks.

The readiness audit

Two weeks before your exam, score yourself honestly against this table. Any 'no' is your remaining agenda - and it is fixable, because it is a behaviour, not a talent:

Check	Standard
Mock volume	12+ full mocks analysed in the error log by exam week
Attempt volume	CHSL / CPO Tier-1 style: 90+ questions attempted per mock, held over three consecutive mocks
Accuracy	Above 85 percent on attempted questions across the last three mocks
Sectional rhythm	Able to run any single section inside its 15-minute clock without panic
Typing (CHSL)	35 wpm English or 30 wpm Hindi sustained over a 10-minute passage
Running (CPO)	1.6 km under 6:30 twice in the last month without injury
Running (GD)	5 km under 24:00 twice in the last month without injury
Documents	Folder complete: certificates, domicile (GD), licence (Delhi Police SI), printouts
Body clock	Sleeping and waking at exam-day times for the last week

16. Exam day, and everything after

The computer-based exam day is choreographed: reach the centre well before the reporting time on your Admission Certificate, carry the printed certificate plus an original photo ID, and expect biometric capture and photograph matching at entry - your appearance must match your application photograph, which is why the photo rules in Section 9 exist. Leave phones, smartwatches and every electronic item at home or with your escort; the unfair-means rules are severe, running to multi-year debarments.

The screen you will actually face

Every SSC computer-based paper runs on the same familiar interface, and knowing it in advance is free marks. One question at a time in the centre of the screen, four options as radio buttons, and three buttons under it: 'Save and Next' (answer and move on), 'Mark for Review and Next' (flag it and come back if time remains), and 'Clear Response'. On the right sits the question palette: green for answered, red for visited but unanswered, purple for marked for review, grey for not yet visited - your live map of the paper. The countdown timer sits at the top, and in the sectional-timer papers (CHSL Tier-I, CPO Paper-I) it counts down each section independently and moves you on when it expires, whether you are done or not. The paper submits itself when the final timer ends. Rough sheets are provided at the centre and collected after; practise your first ten minutes of any mock with this exact behaviour - visit every question once, flag the doubtful, bank the certain, and never leave the palette red at the end of a paper where guessing has positive value (Section 12's table).

If you qualify for a scribe

Eligible PwBD candidates can opt for a scribe; the CHSL notice's process is worth reading in full because it is unusual: your own scribe must have completed OTR with Aadhaar authentication, and when your Admission Certificate goes live you key in the scribe's OTR number - an OTP goes to the scribe's registered mobile, and the entry pass generates only once that OTP is entered. A scribe who is also a candidate of the same examination is barred; both candidatures are cancelled.

After the paper

- Tentative answer keys are published on ssc.gov.in; challenges cost Rs 50 per question, online, within the window (Section 12).
- Multi-shift scores are normalized; results follow the final keys.
- Each exam then runs its own back half: CHSL's Tier-II with its typing test, CPO's PET/PST then Paper-II, JE's Paper-II, GD's PET/PST and medicals.
- Document verification brings the originals: qualification certificates, category and EWS certificates in the prescribed format, domicile certificate for GD, and - for male Delhi Police SI candidates - that driving licence.

The document folder

Start it this week, not the week before verification: Class 10 (DOB) and qualification certificates and marksheets, category / EWS certificate in prescribed format, domicile certificate, Aadhaar, a dozen recent passport photographs, and printouts of every application and fee receipt. One physical folder, one cloud folder. Candidates lose years of preparation to a document that took ten days to reissue.

17. Scam protection

Recruitment seasons attract fraud the way festivals attract crowds, and every year candidates lose money and, worse, genuine opportunities. The rules are simple and absolute.

- One website: ssc.gov.in. The old ssc.nic.in no longer hosts applications. No other site - however official it looks, however similar its logo - accepts SSC applications.
- One fee: Rs 100 per exam, paid inside the portal, with women, SC, ST, PwBD and Ex-Servicemen exempt. Anyone quoting a higher 'government fee', a 'form service charge' or a 'registration assistance charge' is committing fraud.
- No agent, no guarantee: SSC recruitments have no middlemen. 'Payment for confirmed selection' offers are criminal frauds - report them, do not negotiate with them.
- Fake notices circulate every season, usually with inflated vacancies (five-digit vacancy claims before a notification exists are the tell). Before believing any forwarded PDF, find it on ssc.gov.in's notice board; if it is not there, it is fiction.
- Guard your OTR login and OTPs. Nobody legitimate - not SSC, not a 'helpdesk agent' - will ever ask for your password or the OTP on your phone.
- The toll-free helpline for genuine application difficulties is 18003093063. Use it for portal problems, not for rumours.

If someone says this, do this

If someone says	It is	You do
'Pay Rs 500, we will fill your form and guarantee a centre of your choice'	Fraud - the form costs Rs 100 (or nothing) and centres are the Commission's call	Fill it yourself with Section 9 beside you; report the number to the police cyber portal
'Notification is out, 50,000 GD vacancies' - before the notification date, with a PDF attached	A fake notice; real notices appear on ssc.gov.in first	Open ssc.gov.in 's notice board; if it is not there, delete the forward
'Pay a processing fee and your OTR will be fast-tracked'	Fraud - there is no fast lane	Nothing to buy; OTR is free and instant on the official site
'Answer key is leaked, buy it before the exam'	Fraud, and buying it can make you party to an unfair-means case with multi-year debarment	Report it; the only real answer keys are published on ssc.gov.in after the exam
'Pay now and we will adjust your name/category in SSC records'	Fraud - nobody outside the correction window can change anything, and not even then for OTR-locked fields	Use the correction window yourself; take printouts of everything you submit
'Our institute is SSC's official partner'	False - SSC has no coaching partners	Choose any coaching on teaching quality alone; the exam content comes only from the notice

Every row of that table ends the same way because every scam ends the same way: the official website, the official notice, the official window. It is unfashionable advice, but it is the only version that pays.

18. Frequently asked questions

Can I apply for more than one SSC exam in this season?

Yes. CHSL, CPO, JE and GD are separate recruitments; you can hold applications in all of them with one OTR, paying Rs 100 for each (exempted categories pay nothing). The only constraint is real: exam dates can clash, and the fee is not refundable.

I am in my final year of Class 12 or degree. Can I apply?

For CHSL 2026, appearing candidates can apply if they possess the qualification by the cut-off date of 7 October 2026. For CPO and JE, the notice's crucial-date rules govern; read the eligibility paragraph of your notice before applying rather than after.

Is Aadhaar compulsory for applying?

No, but completing Aadhaar-based authentication protects your application from the two most common rejection causes - photograph and signature specifications. Candidates who bring their own scribe follow a separate mandatory Aadhaar-authenticated OTR process for the scribe.

When exactly is my exam?

CHSL Tier-I and Tier-II dates are yet to be notified; CPO Paper-I is expected around December 2026; JE Paper-I is tentatively October-November 2026 and Paper-II December 2026; GD's CBE is expected January-March 2027. Admission certificates appear on your login when dates are announced - check ssc.gov.in weekly rather than waiting for news to reach you.

How many GD 2027 vacancies will there be?

Unknown until the notification (expected 30 September 2026). The last cycle advertised 25,487 posts; treat any number circulating before the notification as rumour.

Can women apply for the uniformed posts?

Yes - CPO Sub-Inspector posts are open to women (157 cm height standard, separate PET events, no shot put) and GD Constable recruitment includes women with their own PET and height standards. BRO's LDC post in CHSL is the exception in this season's notices - male candidates only.

Which language can I write in?

GD's paper is offered in 15 languages. CHSL's Tier-I Parts II to IV are set in English, Hindi and the regional language you opted for; the English section is in English. The typing test medium (English or Hindi) is locked at application time.

Is the fee refunded if I do not appear?

No. The notices state that fees once paid are not refunded under any circumstances nor adjusted against any other examination. Apply only for exams you intend to sit - and then sit them.

What computer knowledge do I need?

For the computer-based papers, nothing beyond operating the test interface - it is a point-and-click screen you can learn in any free online mock. CHSL Tier-II's Computer Knowledge Test is a 15-question qualifying module on basic computer literacy, and the LDC typing test is the one that needs daily practice.

What if the website fails on the last day?

The Commission states plainly that it is not responsible for last-day server load or failed logins. This is why every section of this book says the same thing: submit days early, verify payment status, and keep the printout.

Is there any re-checking of answers?

No - no re-evaluation or re-checking exists at any tier. Your only instrument is the tentative answer key challenge, at Rs 50 per question, within the notified window.

My form status shows 'Incomplete'. What now?

Almost always the fee. Open 'Payment Status' inside your login: if SSC has not registered your payment, the form stays 'Incomplete' and will be rejected at the window's close - re-verify, and if a genuine payment failure occurred, pay again within the fee window (the notice allows fee payment a day beyond the form deadline). The toll-free helpline 18003093063 handles portal problems; call it well before the last evening, not on it.

Can I change my exam centre after submitting?

Treat centre choices as final. The correction window allows only the fields each notice lists, centre changes are not part of SSC's usual correction menu, and the Commission reserves the right to allot or divert candidates to any centre anyway. Choose in your first pass with the care of something permanent.

What happens if two exam dates clash?

Nothing automatic - you lose one of the two, and no fee is refunded. This is why multiple applications raise your odds only if their exams are spread across the calendar. CHSL Tier-I and the GD CBE sit in the same January-March band; SSC usually staggers them, but the only protection is checking dates as admit cards release and choosing the exam you are better prepared for.

Do I need a domicile certificate for GD?

Yes, for state-wise vacancies - a domicile or permanent residential certificate of your state is checked at document verification, and its absence voids the candidature. Get it now; it is the slowest document on the list for most states.

Can vacancies increase after I apply?

Yes, and they often do. The 'tentative vacancies' in each notice are updated on the website as user ministries confirm requirements - the CHSL notice directs candidates to the Tentative Vacancy link on ssc.gov.in. Never read a low tentative number as the final word, and never read a rumour as an update.

Appendix A: every date in the season

The complete verified calendar of this season in one table - cut it out, photograph it, stick it on the wall. Confirmed dates come from the official notices; expected dates come from the Commission's published calendar and will be confirmed in the notifications.

What	Date / window	Status
JE 2026: application window	2 - 22 September 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
JE 2026: fee payment until	23 September 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
CPO 2026: application window	10 - 30 September 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
GD Constable 2027: notification	30 September 2026	Expected (calendar)
JE 2026: correction window	28 - 30 September 2026	Confirmed (notice)
JE 2026: fee payment until	23 September 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
GD Constable 2027: application window	30 September - 31 October 2026	Expected (calendar)
CPO 2026: fee payment until	1 October 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
CHSL 2026: application window closes	7 October 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
CHSL 2026: fee payment until	8 October 2026 (23:00)	Confirmed (notice)
CPO 2026: correction window	8 - 10 October 2026	Confirmed (notice)

What	Date / window	Status
CHSL 2026: correction window	14 - 16 October 2026	Confirmed (notice)
JE 2026: Paper-I	October - November 2026	Tentative (notice)
MTS 2026: computer-based exam	September - November 2026	Per calendar
JE 2026: Paper-II	December 2026	Tentative (notice)
CGL 2026: Tier-II	December 2026	Per calendar
CPO 2026: Paper-I	Around December 2026	Expected
GD Constable 2027: computer-based exam	January - March 2027	Expected (calendar)
CHSL 2026: Tier-I and Tier-II	To be notified	Watch ssc.gov.in

The one habit that protects all these dates

A weekly calendar alarm - every Sunday, five minutes, ssc.gov.in notice board. Every date in this table was announced on the notice board before it was news anywhere else, and every date in this book can be revised by the Commission. The candidates who miss windows are never the ones who checked weekly.

Appendix B: speak SSC - a glossary

The notices are written in an alphabet soup that becomes second nature within a week of using it. This is the whole soup, decoded.

Term	What it means
CBE	Computer Based Examination - the online multiple-choice paper, taken at a test centre terminal
Tier / Paper	The stages of a written exam (CHSL has Tier-I and Tier-II; CPO and JE have Paper-I and Paper-II)
OTR	One-Time Registration - your permanent SSC account on ssc.gov.in, used for every exam you ever apply to
AC	Admission Certificate - the admit card, downloadable from your login when exam dates are announced
PST	Physical Standard Test - measurement of height, chest and weight against the prescribed standards
PET	Physical Endurance Test - the performance events: races, jumps, shot put
DME / RME	Detailed / Review Medical Examination - the medical check after the physicals; one review pass is allowed under the GD scheme
DV	Document Verification - where every certificate you claimed is checked in original
FRTA	First Round of Tentative Allocation - SSC's sliding-mechanism first round of post allotment after the final result; candidates who do not submit their online post preferences in time are left out of it entirely
Normalization	The statistical adjustment of scores across shifts of different difficulty, applied before cut-offs and merit (SSC's procedure of 2 June 2025)
Cut-off	The minimum marks to clear a stage; category-wise and sometimes post-group-wise separate cut-offs apply
Negative marking	Marks subtracted per wrong answer - 0.25 to 1.00 depending on the paper (see Section 12's table)
Sectional timer	A fixed time allowed per section of the paper, introduced in CHSL Tier-I and the new CPO papers
Pay Level	The Seventh Pay Commission grade fixing basic pay (Level-2 to Level-6 in this season's posts)

Term	What it means
Basic pay / DA / HRA	Your fixed salary component; Dearness Allowance (inflation-linked) and House Rent Allowance (city-class-linked) are added on top
EWS	Economically Weaker Sections - 10 percent reservation, claimed with a valid Income and Asset certificate (for CHSL: valid for FY 2026-27, based on FY 2025-26 income)
PwBD	Person with Benchmark Disability (40 percent or more) - reservation, fee exemption, scribe and compensatory-time provisions
ESM	Ex-Servicemen - reservation, fee exemption, and exemption from PET (PST still applies)
NCC bonus	Extra marks in CPO final merit for NCC certificates, per the notice
wpm / key depressions	Typing speed measures: words per minute (35 English / 30 Hindi for LDC) or key depressions per hour (8,000-15,000 for DEO posts)
Domicile certificate	State residence proof required for GD's state-wise vacancies at document verification
LMV licence	Driving licence for Light Motor Vehicles (car and motorcycle) - mandatory for male Delhi Police SI candidates by the PET date
Tentative vacancies	The initial vacancy count in a notice, updated on the website as user ministries confirm posts

Appendix C: the whole season on one page

If you remember nothing else from this handbook, remember this page.

- Four windows: JE 2026 closes 22 September; CPO 2026 closes 30 September; CHSL 2026 closes 7 October; GD Constable 2027 opens 30 September (expected). Apply inside the first five days of any window, never the last five.
- One account: One-Time Registration on ssc.gov.in. The old website's OTR is dead. Aadhaar authentication protects you from the two biggest rejection causes.
- Three fees-facts: Rs 100 per exam; women, SC, ST, PwBD and Ex-Servicemen pay nothing; fees are never refunded - and an unlinked fee rejects the form, so check 'Payment Status'.
- Two numbers per paper: questions and penalty. Every paper in this season has negative marking from -0.25 to -1.00 (Section 12's table), and in every paper except CHSL Tier-II even a blind guess has positive expected value - so fill the palette.
- One selection logic: the written papers shortlist; the physical tests, typing tests and document verification eliminate; the final merit and your post preferences decide the post. Show up for every stage, including the online option forms.
- Sixteen weeks: reasoning, quantitative aptitude, English, general awareness - the same four subjects for every exam in this season. One error log, weekly mocks with timers, typing or running on the side.
- One habit: five minutes on ssc.gov.in every Sunday. Every date in this book can be revised; the notice board is where revisions appear first.
- One website: ssc.gov.in. No agents, no guarantees, no shortcuts.

19. Sources and disclaimer

Every exam fact in this handbook was verified against the following official material published by the Staff Selection Commission on ssc.gov.in:

- Notice of the Combined Higher Secondary (10+2) Level Examination, 2026, dated 7 September 2026 (application dates, 2,536 tentative vacancies, posts and pay levels, age rules and relaxations, Tier-I and Tier-II schemes, typing and skill test standards, merit rules, OTR and application rules, unfair-means penalties).
- Notice of the Junior Engineer Examination, 2026, dated 2 September 2026 (dates, 1,748 vacancies, pay level, qualification and age rules, Paper-I and Paper-II schemes, fee and correction rules).
- Notice of the Sub-Inspector in Delhi Police and Central Armed Police Forces Examination, 2026, dated 10 September 2026 (dates, posts, revised Paper-I and Paper-II patterns, PET and PST standards, selection stages).
- Notice for recruitment of Constable (GD) in CAPFs, SSF and Rifleman (GD) in Assam Rifles (CBE scheme of 80 questions for 160 marks, PET/PST standards, domicile and medical rules), together with widely reported details of the 2026 cycle.
- The Commission's published Annual Examination Calendar 2026-27 (GD 2027 notification and exam-month expectations, MTS, CGL and Stenographer status).

Where this handbook reports an expectation - the GD 2027 notification date, exam-month windows, and next-cycle timing - it is drawn from the Commission's published calendar or the standard recruitment cycle, and is labelled as expected rather than confirmed.

Disclaimer

This is an independent study guide. It is not published by, affiliated with or endorsed by the Staff Selection Commission or any government body. Recruitment rules, dates, vacancies and patterns are revised by the Commission from time to time; the only authoritative source is always the official notice of the day on ssc.gov.in. Read this handbook with the notice of your examination open beside it.

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